SPACE AGENCY RACE

A COMPETITIVE STRATEGY CARD GAME

"We are running a space agency under pressure: engineering constraints, launch timing, and strategic trade-offs matter."

Players	Playtime	Age	Complexity
2 – 4	30 – 45 min	12 +	Medium

01

Welcome to Space Agency Race

In **Space Agency Race**, you lead a rival space agency competing for glory and government contracts. Design rockets from a shared pool of cards, accept daring missions, manage your credits, and launch craft toward the Moon, Mars, and beyond. The agency that banks the most **Victory Points (VP)** wins.

★ CORE FANTASY

Engineering trade-offs, careful planning, and bold decisions define your agency. Pick the right engine for the job, time your launches against the Transfer Window, and decide whether to reuse reliable hardware or push experimental technology to score prestige missions.

CARD DRAFTING

Buy components from the Card Market — engines, tanks, payloads, and support gear.

ACTION SELECTION

Each round your Agency Level determines how many Command Turns you control.

RESOURCE MANAGEMENT

Credits fund your operations. Missions are your primary source of income.

CARD SYNERGY

Technology upgrades and tag combinations reward long-term strategy.

02

Components

Card Types

Engine Cards

Supply **Thrust** to lift payloads from a planet. Engines have a **Reliability** rating checked on launch. They may be Reusable, Disposable, or Stageable — each with its own trade-off of cost, reliability, and repeat-flight value.

Fuel Tank Cards

Provide **Range** — the distance your rocket can travel across the orbital map. Each tank also has a **Mass** value that your engine must be able to lift. A rocket may carry **1–3 Fuel Tanks**; total Range is the sum of all tanks. Stageable tanks can be jettisoned mid-flight for a bonus.

Payload Cards

Satellites, probes, crew capsules, landers, and return capsules. Each payload has a **Mass** value that adds to the rocket's total weight. Satellites and Stations remain on the orbital board as persistent assets after delivery.

Support Cards

Heat shields, parachutes, docking adapters, and other hardware. Landing support is needed for atmospheric reentry; docking support is required for Docking missions. Reusable versions return to your hand if the craft makes it back to Earth.

Mission Cards

Contracts that score VP and Credits. Each mission shows a Conditions list (destination route + hardware requirements), while reward badges show VP and Credits. In this prototype, all missions are Public and sorted into three Tiers of difficulty.

Technology Cards

Permanent upgrades placed in your Agency Tableau. They improve reliability, reduce Mass, or unlock new capabilities. Technologies remain active until another card effect removes them.

Event Cards

Global effects that last one round — funding boosts, solar storms, transfer window shifts, and docking opportunities. One Event is flipped each round during the Planning Phase. If the Event Deck runs out, skip the Event reveal.

Card Stats at a Glance

THRUST

Engine lifting power. Must be ≥ the rocket's total Mass (sum of all tank Mass + payload Mass).

RANGE

Fuel tank stat. Total Range = sum of all tanks. Spent 1 per node crossed on the orbital map.

MASS

Weight of tanks (1–4) and payloads (1–3). Engine Thrust must be ≥ total Mass to launch.

ENERGY

Electricity used by active systems. Generators add Energy at the start of the Action Phase; batteries store Energy between rounds.

RELIABILITY

Engine stat (1–10). On launch, roll 1d10: success if roll ≤ Reliability + Tech bonuses − Event penalties. Checked on launch only, not on in-flight activations.

VP

Victory Points awarded on mission completion.

COST

Credits required to acquire this card from the Card Market.

In-Card Text Icons

Card rule text uses these inline badges instead of writing out keyword names in full:

VP Victory Points — scored on mission completion.

CR Credits (CR) — the game currency used to draft cards and pay costs.

Other Components

- **1 Orbital Board** — Combined VP track, orbital node map, and Transfer Window track
- **VP Markers** (1 per player) — Tracked openly on the shared board
- **Credit Markers** (1 per player) — Tracked openly on each player's Credit track
- **Agency Level Markers** (1 per player) — Start at Level 1
- **Craft Markers** (6 per player) — Represent rockets and in-orbit assets on the board
- **Range Tokens / Small Dice** — Track remaining Range per craft on the board

- **Energy Tokens** — Track generated Energy on in-flight craft and stored Energy on Battery cards
- **Transfer Window Marker** — Tracks the current TW cost (0–5) on the board track
- **1 First Player Token**

Shared Areas

- **Card Market** — 5 face-up component cards available for purchase. Refilled immediately when a card is bought and topped up during Maintenance.
- **Component Deck** — All Engines, Tanks, Payloads, Support, and Technology cards shuffled together into one draw pile.
- **Event Deck** — Shuffled separately. One card flipped per round.
- **Mission Deck & Display** — 3 face-up missions. Refilled during Maintenance.

03

Setup

01 Each player **chooses a color** and receives: **Sterling Booster** (E02, Basic Engine), **Standard Tank** (T01, Basic Tank), **Heat Shield** (S01, Basic Support), 5 Credits, 1 Credit marker, 1 VP marker (placed on 0), 1 Agency Level marker (set to Level 1), and 6 Craft markers.

02 **Sort Mission cards by Tier.** Shuffle the Tier 1 Mission stack and place it face-down as the Mission deck. Set Tier 2 and Tier 3 Missions aside face-down — they enter the game later.

03 **Reveal 3 Tier 1 Mission cards** face-up to form the starting Mission display.

04 Shuffle all remaining component cards (Engines, Tanks, Payloads, Support, Technology) into one **Component Deck**. Shuffle the **Event Deck** separately.

05 **Reveal 5 Component cards** face-up to form the starting **Card Market**.

06 **Determine the first player** randomly. Give them the First Player token.

07 The game lasts **8 rounds**, or ends sooner if the Mission deck runs out.

💡 BASIC CARDS

Cards tagged Basic (Sterling Booster, Standard Tank, Heat Shield) are **always available** for purchase at their printed cost — even if none appear in the Card Market. Any player may buy a Basic card as an Acquire Card action at any time.

SAMPLE STARTING SETUP — 3 PLAYERS

EXAMPLE

Each player holds: 1 Sterling Booster (Thrust 5, Reliability 9), 1 Standard Tank (Range 5, Mass 2), 1 Heat Shield, and 5 Credits. The Mission display shows *LEO Deployment*, *Emergency Resupply*, and *Capsule Recovery* — all Tier 1 contracts. The Card Market shows 5 random component cards.

04

Round Structure

Each game round proceeds through **three phases** in order. Launches and in-flight activations resolve **immediately** during the Action Phase — there is no separate resolution phase.

Phase 01

Planning

Reveal an Event. Advance the Transfer Window. Each player draws 2 cards (hand limit 5). Optional: discard 1 card for 1 Credit.

Phase 02

Action

Players alternate Command Turns equal to their Agency Level. In-flight craft first generate Energy, then launch, build, buy, and fly. Missions resolve immediately on arrival.

Phase 03

Maintenance

Recover Reusable parts. Discard the Event. Refill the Mission display to 3 and the Card Market to 5.

Planning Phase Detail

1. **Reveal Event:** Flip the top card of the Event Deck. Its effect applies for the entire round. If the Event Deck is empty, skip this step.
2. **Advance Transfer Window:** Move the TW marker one step along its track (range 0–5).
3. **Draw Cards:** Each player draws **2 cards** from the Component Deck. Hand limit is **5** — if you exceed 5, immediately discard down.
4. **Emergency Sell:** Each player may discard 1 card from hand to gain 1 Credit.

Maintenance Phase Detail

- Reusable parts from craft that returned to Earth go back to hand (if not staged).
- Ongoing technology effects trigger.
- Each Battery card may store up to 1 unused generated Energy from its craft, up to its capacity.
- Discard all other unused generated Energy tokens from in-flight craft.
- Discard the current round's Event card.
- Refill the Mission display to 3 cards if needed.
- Refill the **Card Market** to 5 cards from the Component Deck.

Energy Timing

- **Start of Action Phase:** Each in-flight craft gains generated Energy equal to the total generation of its attached cards.
- **Spend Energy:** When a card tells you to spend Energy, remove that many Energy tokens from the craft or from its Battery cards.
- **Stored Energy:** Battery cards keep stored Energy between rounds and enter play full when their craft launches.
- **Unused Energy:** Generated Energy is lost during Maintenance unless a Battery stores it.

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Actions

On your Command Turn, choose one action:

◆ Acquire Card

Buy one face-up card from the **Card Market** (or any Basic card) by paying its Credit cost. Add it to your hand. Immediately refill the empty market slot.

◆ Sell Part

Discard a card from your hand and gain Credits equal to half its Cost, rounded down.

◆ Accept Mission

Commit to one Public mission in the display. In this prototype, all missions remain public and may be raced by multiple agencies until completed.

◆ Assemble Rocket

Play Engine, Tanks, Payload, and/or Support cards to your Launch Area. A rocket needs an Engine to launch from a planet.

◆ Develop Technology

Pay a Technology card's Credit cost and place it face-up in your **Agency Tableau**. It applies to all your craft permanently. You cannot have two developed Technology cards with the same **Name**.

◆ Upgrade Rocket

Replace one or more components on an assembled rocket in your Launch Area.

◆ Launch New Craft

Place an assembled rocket at Earth, perform the **Launch Capability Check** and **Reliability Check**, then fly along the orbital map. Resolve the mission immediately if the craft reaches its destination. *You may combine Assemble Rocket and Launch New Craft into a single Command Turn if all components are already in your hand.*

◆ Activate Craft

Spend remaining Range to move one of your in-flight craft along the orbital map. Spend Energy too if an attached card requires it for that activation. Each craft may be activated only once per Action Phase. May resolve a mission on arrival.

◆ Expand Agency

Increase your Agency Level by paying Credits. Takes effect at the start of your next round.

Agency Levels

Expanding your agency unlocks additional Command Turns each round, letting you operate more craft and advance faster.

LEVEL

1

1 Command Turn

Starting level — no cost

LEVEL

2

2 Command Turns

Costs 6 Credits

LEVEL

3

3 Command Turns

Costs 14 Credits

⚠ MISSION TIER UNLOCKS

When the *first* agency reaches Level 2, immediately shuffle all **Tier 2 Missions** into the Mission deck.

When the *first* agency reaches Level 3, immediately shuffle all **Tier 3 Missions** into the Mission deck and that player gains **+2 VP**.

Each unlock happens only once per game. The player with the lowest VP gains a **Government Catch-Up Grant** at each unlock: **+3 Credits** at Tier 2, **+4 Credits** at Tier 3. If tied on VP, the tied player with fewest Credits gains the grant — or each tied player gains 2 Credits if still tied.

🌍 MILESTONE VP BONUSES

- **First to Moon branch** (Moon Orbit or farther): **+2 VP**
- **First to Mars branch** (Mars ZOI or farther): **+4 VP**
- **Tech pace bonus:** first player to develop 4 Technologies gains **+2 VP**
- **Orbit-linked innovation:** if you develop a Technology while you control an on-orbit Satellite or Station, gain **+1 VP** (max once per round)

06

Rocket Design

Assemble a rocket in your Launch Area from:

- **0–1 Engine** (required to launch from a planet)

- **1–3 Fuel Tanks** (total Range = sum of all tanks)
- **0–1 Payload**
- **0–3 Support Cards**

Mass & Thrust

Every Fuel Tank and Payload has a numeric **Mass** value. Some Support cards also print Mass. To launch, the Engine's **Thrust** must be **≥ Total Rocket Mass**.

> **Total Rocket Mass** = sum of all Fuel Tank Mass values + Payload Mass + any printed Support Mass
>
> **Launch Capability Check** = Engine Thrust ≥ Total Rocket Mass

Engines have no Mass for launch-capability purposes. Support cards count only if they print a Mass value. If a rocket has no Payload, only tank Mass and printed Support Mass count.

Design note — physics in two stats: Space Agency abstracts rocket science into two clean levers. **Thrust** models thrust-to-weight ratio: can this engine lift the fully-loaded stack off the pad? **Range** models total delta-v budget after liftoff: how far can the craft travel? **Staging** models the real-world mass-ratio gain of dropping spent boosters — a lighter post-stage vehicle can reach farther destinations with the same remaining fuel. The **Transfer Window** models Hohmann transfer timing: like real interplanetary windows, launching at optimal planetary alignment dramatically cuts the Range needed to reach Mars. None of this requires knowing the Tsiolkovsky rocket equation — the card stats handle the math.

Component	Mass Range	Examples
Fuel Tanks	1 – 4	Fuel Pod (1), Standard (2), Cryo (3), Long-Range (4)
Payloads	1 – 3	CubeSat (1), Comm Satellite (2), Science Module (3)
Supports	usually —	Most have no Mass; RTG has Mass 1
Engines	—	Thrust 3–9; no Mass value

Energy Systems

Some Support and Payload cards use **Energy**. Energy is tracked with tokens on each craft.

- **Generation:** Solar Panels and RTGs add Energy at the start of the Action Phase.
- **Use:** Cards such as Docking Adapters, Orbital Tugs, Sensors, and Flight Computers spend Energy when activated.
- **Storage:** Battery cards keep stored Energy between rounds and can hold unused generated Energy.
- **Battery recharge:** During Maintenance, each Battery may store up to 1 unused generated Energy from its craft.

Staging

Cards with the Stageable tag can be jettisoned for a one-time Range bonus printed on the card.

- **Pre-flight staging:** After the launch capability check, before movement, you may Stage one Stageable card. Gain its printed bonus Range. The staged card is discarded.
- **Mid-flight staging:** At any point during movement (between nodes), you may Stage one Stageable card (typically an empty tank). Gain its bonus Range and reduce the craft's current Mass — important for relaunch capability checks.
- A staged Engine still counts for the initial launch capability check.
- Staging reduces the craft's current Mass (important for relaunch capability checks) and increases Range.
- A staged card is **discarded** and cannot be recovered, even if Reusable.

EXAMPLE

STAGING EXAMPLE

You assemble a **Kick Stage** (Thrust 7, Stageable) plus a Standard Tank (Range 5, Mass 2) and a Science Module (Mass 3, Heavy). Total Mass = 5 ≤ Thrust 7 ✓. You declare the Kick Stage staged pre-flight: gain +2 Range bonus, giving total Range of 7. The Kick Stage is discarded. The rocket flies with 7 Range.

Example Rockets

ENGINE

Sterling Booster

Thrust 5 · Reliability 9 · Cost 3

Disposable · Basic

High reliability, single-use. Always available.

FUEL TANK

Standard Tank

Range 5 · Mass 2 · Cost 2

Stable · Basic

Compatible with most engines. Always available.

PAYLOAD

Comm Satellite

Mass 2 · Cost 2

Satellite · Uncrewed

Remains on board as an on-orbit asset after delivery.

SUPPORT

Heat Shield

Cost 1

Heat Shield · Basic

Use from Sub-Orbital to land safely. Always available.

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Orbital Travel

Range is your rocket's travel budget — a simplified representation of delta-v. Each line crossed on the orbital map costs **1 Range**, except the **Transfer Window** crossing which costs **0–5 extra Range** depending on planetary alignment. When launched or activated, a craft may move **any number of nodes up to its remaining Range** in a single action. Players may voluntarily stop at any node, preserving unspent Range for future activations. For Earth-orbit mission effects, **High Orbit** is treated as **GEO**.

Orbital Node Map (15 Nodes)

EARTH BRANCH

Earth → 1 → Sub-Orbital Earth → 1 → LEO → 1 → High Orbit → 1

MOON BRANCH (from Earth ZOI)

Earth ZOI → 1 → Moon Orbit → 1 → Sub-Orbital Moon → 1 → Moon

MARS BRANCH (from Earth ZOI)

Earth ZOI → 1 → Sun Orbit → TW → Mars ZOI → 1 → Mars High Orbit

Each arrow costs **1 Range** except the **Transfer Window** crossing (Sun Orbit → Mars ZOI) which costs the current **TW value (0–5)**. Reverse the path for return trips — TW cost applies each crossing.

Transfer Window

◈ PLANETARY ALIGNMENT

The Transfer Window represents planetary alignment for interplanetary transfers. Its cost (**TW**, range 0–5) changes each round along a track printed on the board. Event cards may also modify TW for a round.

- **TW 0** — Perfect window; the crossing is free.
- **TW 5** — Worst alignment; costs 5 extra Range.

Mars missions reward timing. A launch during TW 0 saves up to 5 Range compared to TW 5.

Node Distances from Earth

Node	Distance	Notes
Sub-Orbital Earth	1	
LEO	2	
High Orbit (GEO)	3	Earth-orbit GEO effects use this node
Earth ZOI	4	Boundary; branches to Moon and Mars
Moon Orbit	5	

Node	Distance	Notes
Sub-Orbital Moon	6	
Moon (surface)	7	
Sun Orbit	5	Mars branch start
Transfer Window →	5 + TW	TW = 0–5 per round
Mars ZOI	6 + TW	
Mars High Orbit	7 + TW	
Mars Low Orbit	8 + TW	
Sub-Orbital Mars	9 + TW	
Mars Surface	10 + TW	

Landing

To land on a body, a craft must be at the adjacent **Sub-Orbital** node and spend **1 Range** to reach the surface.

Body	Landing Method
Earth	Use a Heat Shield or Parachute (discard after use), **or** propulsive landing (1 extra Range + Engine).
Moon	**Propulsive only** (no atmosphere). Requires Engine. Use a Landing Lander **or** Rocket-as-Lander.
Mars	Use a Heat Shield or Parachute (thin atmosphere), **or** propulsive landing (1 extra Range + Engine). Landing Lander or Rocket-as-Lander for surface missions.

Rocket-as-Lander

🚀 LANDING WITHOUT A LANDER

A rocket does **not** need a separate Landing Lander to land. If it has an **Engine** and enough **remaining Range**, it can land directly. To **relaunch from a surface**, the craft must pass a new Launch Capability Check (Thrust ≥ current Mass, accounting for staged-away cards) and a new **Reliability Check**.

Dedicated landers are still valuable because they free up Range for the rest of the trip. Players can stage away empty tanks before relaunching to reduce Mass.

Persistent Assets

Payloads with the `Satellite` or `Station` tag remain on the orbital board after delivery. They use Craft markers and may be activated in future rounds like any other craft.

On-Orbit Stations

High Orbit (GEO) is the station node on the Earth branch. A parked station occupies that node and can be visited by docking missions.

- A craft parked at High Orbit (GEO) may be designated an **On-Orbit Station** if it includes a **Station Hub** payload, at least one attached `Power` card, at least one attached `LifeSupport` card, and at least one additional `Scientific` or `Electronics` card.
- Once designated, the craft remains parked in High Orbit (GEO) until an effect moves it. Docking missions and station-related Events target any such On-Orbit Station.
- Support cards attached to the station stay with it while it remains in orbit.

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Launch Resolution

When a craft is **launched** or **activated**, resolve flight immediately during the Action Phase:

1. **Launch Capability Check.** Verify Engine Thrust ≥ Total Rocket Mass (sum of all Fuel Tank Mass + Payload Mass). A rocket launched from a planet must have an Engine. In this game, Thrust answers "can this stack leave the surface?" while Range answers "how much orbital travel can it still perform?"

2. **Reliability Check.** Roll a d10. If the result is **≤ the Engine's Reliability** (after modifiers from Technology and Events), the launch succeeds. If the roll is **above** Reliability: the craft does not move; non-Reusable Engines are discarded, Reusable Engines survive but the craft still doesn't launch. *Skip this step when activating a craft already in flight. A Rocket-as-Lander relaunching from a surface must pass a new Reliability Check.*

3. **Optional Pre-Flight Staging.** Stage one `Stageable` card. Gain its printed bonus Range. The staged card is discarded.

4. **Choose Path & Move.** The craft moves along the orbital map, spending 1 Range per node crossed (Transfer Window crossing costs the current TW value). The player may **stop at any node**, preserving unspent Range for future activations.

5. **Mid-Flight Staging.** At any point between nodes, stage a `Stageable` card (typically an empty tank) to gain bonus Range and reduce Mass for relaunch checks. The staged card is discarded.

6. **Track Remaining Range.** Place a token or die beside the craft marker on the board showing unspent Range.

7. **Check Mission Requirements.** If the craft reaches the mission destination, verify payload, tags, and special conditions.

8. **Apply Special Effects.** Trigger any card or event bonuses.

9. **Score VP & Rewards.** Gain mission VP and Credits immediately.

Recovery

- If a craft returns to the **Earth** node, all unstaged `Reusable` parts return to your hand during Maintenance.
- Staged parts are *always* lost — reusability does not apply to them.
- Non-Reusable parts are discarded unless another card effect says otherwise.
- If a craft *remains in space*, all its parts stay attached to the craft.

- A craft with **0 remaining Range** cannot move but stays on the board as a persistent asset (if applicable).

EXAMPLE

FULL LAUNCH EXAMPLE

You assemble a **Hydrogen Core** (Thrust 8, Reliability 7) + **Cryo Tank** (Range 8, Mass 3) + **Standard Tank** (Range 5, Mass 2) + **Imaging Probe** (Mass 1) for a *Lunar Flyby* mission (Route: Earth → Moon Orbit → Earth, Range 10).

Launch Capability Check: Total Mass = 3 + 2 + 1 = 6 ≤ Thrust 8 ✓. **Reliability Check:** Roll d10 → 4 ≤ 7 ✓ Success! Total Range = 8 + 5 = 13. Fly: Earth → Sub-Orbital Earth → LEO → High Orbit (GEO) → Earth ZOI → Moon Orbit (5 Range spent). Fly back: Moon Orbit → Earth ZOI → High Orbit (GEO) → LEO → Sub-Orbital Earth → Earth (5 more = 10 total, 3 Range left over). Mission route completed! Score **7 VP + 2 Credits**. During Maintenance, the Hydrogen Core (non-Reusable) is discarded. The Cryo Tank and Standard Tank are discarded. The Imaging Probe, now operating as a small science satellite at Moon Orbit, stays on the board.

09

Missions

Mission cards are your agency's contract system. Each card shows a Conditions list for destination route and hardware requirements. Rewards are shown as VP and Credits badges.

Mission Market

Public Missions

In the current prototype, every mission is public. Multiple agencies can race to complete the same mission, and the card leaves the display only when completed.

Commercial Contracts

Commercial missions pay more Credits than VP. They model launch services, resupply work, and operational support that fund your next builds.

Prestige & Infrastructure Contracts

Prestige missions pay more VP than Credits and represent headline exploration achievements. Infrastructure missions sit between the two, often enabling later station or satellite rewards.

Mission Tiers

Tier	Unlocks When	Mission Focus
Tier 1	Available from the start	Earth orbit, sub-orbital returns, LEO deployments
Tier 2	First agency reaches Level 2	Lunar missions, orbital assets, science relays, crewed station visits
Tier 3	First agency reaches Level 3	Mars missions, deep space probes, sample returns, crewed Mars flights

Mission Requirements

- Missions with the Docking tag require a **Docking-tagged support card** on the rocket (e.g., Docking Adapter or Orbital Tug) and a valid **On-Orbit Station** in High Orbit (GEO) to dock with.
- Missions with the Docking or Maneuver tags require an Engine.
- Missions with the Surface tag require a Landing Lander or Rocket-as-Lander.
- Mission cards that cross the Transfer Window show route Range at TW 0. Add the current TW cost when planning.

Sample Mission Cards

🪐 MISSION · T1

🌍

LEO Deployment

🪐 MISSION · T2

🌙

Lunar Landing

🪐 MISSION · T3

🔴

Mars Orbit Insertion

Range 2 · Reward: 2 VP + 5 CR

Public

Commercial

Route: Earth → LEO. Requires: Uncrewed payload.

Range 7 · Reward: 9 VP + 3 CR

Public Prestige

Route: Earth → Moon. Requires: Lander or Rocket-as-Lander.

Range 7+TW · Reward: 13 VP + 3 CR

Public Prestige

Route: Earth → Mars High Orbit. Crosses Transfer Window. Mass 2+ payload.

MISSION · T3

Lunar Sample Return

Range 14 · Reward: 13 VP + 3 CR

Prestige Public

Route: Earth → Moon → Earth. Lander or Rocket-as-Lander + Cargo Return + reentry support.

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Technology

Technology cards are permanent upgrades. Pay the card's Credit cost and place it face-up in your **Agency Tableau**. Once active, it applies to all your craft for the rest of the game. You cannot develop another Technology with the same **Name**. Technologies are removed only by another card effect.

EXAMPLE TECHNOLOGIES

- **Reusable Refurb** — Your Reusable engines gain +1 Reliability. When you recover a Reusable card during Maintenance, gain 1 Credit.
- **Cryo Handling** — Your rockets that include a Cryo Tank gain +1 Reliability on launch checks.
- **Precision Guidance** — +1 effective Reliability on all launch checks.

- **Modular Payloads** — Reduce your payload's Mass by 1 (minimum 1) for Thrust checks.

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Scoring & End Game

The game ends after **8 rounds**, or sooner when the Mission deck is depleted. After the final round, all players compare the VP they earned during play from:

- Missions completed during the game
- Milestone bonuses (first to Moon/Mars, first to Level 3, and technology milestones)
- Card and Event effects that grant VP during play, such as docking bonuses or research activations

The player with the **highest VP total wins**.

⚖ TIEBREAKERS

1. Most completed Missions
2. Most remaining Credits

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Complete Example Turn

EXAMPLE

ROUND 3 — AGENCY "STARBOUND" (LEVEL 2, TW = 1)

Planning Phase: An Event is flipped — *Launch Window* (TW reduced by 2 this round, so TW is now 0 instead of 1). The TW marker advances one step. Each player draws 2 cards from the Component Deck. Starbound draws a Cryo Tank and an Imaging Probe. Hand size is now 5 — at the limit.

Action Phase — Command Turn 1: Starbound pays 5 Credits to **Acquire** a Hydrogen Core engine (Thrust 8, Reliability 7) from the Card Market. The empty slot is immediately refilled. But now hand size is 6 — over the limit of 5! Starbound must discard one card immediately.

Action Phase — Command Turn 2: Starbound combines Assemble and Launch in one Command Turn (legal when all components are in hand). They play **Hydrogen Core + Cryo Tank (Range 8, Mass 3) + Standard Tank (Range 5, Mass 2) + Imaging Probe (Mass 1)** to the Launch Area and immediately launch. **Launch Capability Check:** Total Mass = 3 + 2 + 1 = 6 ≤ Thrust 8 ✓. **Reliability Check:** roll d10 → 3 ≤ 7 ✓ Success! Total Range = 13. The craft flies outbound: Earth → Sub-Orbital Earth → LEO → High Orbit (GEO) → Earth ZOI → Moon Orbit (5 Range). The Imaging Probe detaches at Moon Orbit and stays as a persistent science satellite. The craft returns along the same route (5 more Range = 10 total). Starbound completes *Lunar Flyby* for **7 VP + 2 Credits**, with 3 Range still unspent on the returning craft.

Maintenance Phase: The Event card is discarded. The Mission display is refilled to 3. The Card Market is refilled to 5.

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Card Tags

Tags on cards create connections between hardware requirements and mission conditions. A card with a tag contributes that capability to the craft.

Reusable Returns to hand when craft reaches Earth (if not staged).

Disposable Discarded after launch; never returns to hand.

Stageable Can be jettisoned for a printed bonus Range (pre-flight or mid-flight).

Basic Always available for purchase at printed cost, even if not in the Card Market.

Cryogenic Requires compatible engine (Hydrogen Core); higher Range but heavier Mass.

Experimental Higher risk, potentially higher reward; lower base Reliability.

Crewed Enables crewed missions; requires life-support consideration.

LifeSupport Habitability systems for long-duration crewed craft and stations.

- **Electronics** Computers, comms, and control systems; counts toward station qualification.
- **Power** Generates or stores Energy; required to keep an On-Orbit Station operating.
- **Satellite** Remains on orbital board after delivery as a persistent asset.
- **Station** A permanent orbital facility, usually anchored by a Station Hub in High Orbit (GEO).
- **Heat Shield** Required for atmospheric reentry (Earth/Mars). Discarded after use unless Reusable.
- **Parachute** Alternative to Heat Shield for atmospheric landing.
- **Docking** Support card tag. Required on the rocket for Docking-tagged missions.
- **Commercial** Mission class focused on Credits. Represents launch contracts, logistics, and service work.
- **Prestige** Mission class focused on VP. Represents exploration firsts, science headlines, and public glory.
- **Infrastructure** Mission class with balanced rewards that helps build long-term station and satellite networks.
- **Maneuver** Mission requires orbital maneuvering; Engine mandatory.
- **In-Flight** Mission may be completed by a craft already in flight.
- **On-Orbit** Mission may be completed by a craft currently in orbit.
- **Surface** Mission requires landing on a planetary or lunar surface.
- **Scientific** Payload carries scientific instruments; gates certain mission requirements.
- **Deep Space** Mission or payload related to interplanetary destinations.

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Glossary

Term	Definition
Agency Level	Your operation scale (1–3). Determines how many Command Turns you take each Action Phase.
Agency Tableau	Your personal area of face-up Technology cards. Their effects apply to all your craft permanently.

Term	Definition
Basic Card	A card tagged Basic (E02, T01, S01) that can always be purchased at printed cost, even if not in the Card Market.
Card Market	5 face-up component cards. Refilled immediately when a card is bought and during Maintenance.
Command Turn	One action taken during the Action Phase. You take one at a time, alternating with other players.
Component Deck	All Engines, Tanks, Payloads, Support, and Technology cards shuffled into one draw pile.
Craft	Any assembled rocket, satellite, or station on the orbital board. Each may be activated once per Action Phase.
Credits	Your operating budget. Earned mainly from commercial missions and operational card effects. Used to acquire cards and expand your agency.
Government Catch-Up Grant	Bonus Credits awarded to the trailing player when a new Mission Tier unlocks.
Hand Limit	Maximum 5 cards in hand. Exceed → immediately discard down. EV08 raises it to 7 for one round.
Mass	Weight of tanks (1–4) and payloads (1–3). Combined with Thrust, it determines whether a craft can launch from a surface.
Mission Display	The face-up row of available Mission cards. Refilled from the Mission deck during Maintenance.
On-Orbit Station	A station parked at High Orbit (GEO), created from a Station Hub craft with power, life support, and lab/computer support.
Orbital Board	The shared board showing the VP track, orbital node map, and Transfer Window track.
Range	Abstract delta-v budget for orbital travel. Total = sum of all tank Range values. Each node crossed costs 1 Range.
Reliability	Engine stat (1–10). On launch, roll 1d10: success if ≤ Reliability + Tech bonuses − Event penalties. Checked on launch, not on in-flight activation (except Rocket-as-Lander relaunch).

Term	Definition
Rocket-as-Lander	Landing without a dedicated Lander by using the rocket's Engine + remaining Range. Relaunch requires a new Launch Capability Check + Reliability Check.
Staging	Jettisoning a Stageable card for bonus Range. Pre-flight (after the launch capability check) or mid-flight (between nodes). Reduces Mass and grants bonus Range.
Thrust	Engine launch capability. Must be ≥ total Rocket Mass to leave a surface. It is a launch gate, not a full simulation of the rocket equation.
Transfer Window (TW)	Cost (0–5) to cross from Sun Orbit to Mars ZOI. Changes each round on the board track. Events may modify.
VP (Victory Points)	The prestige currency. Earned from exploration missions, milestones, research, and other headline achievements. Tallied at game end.

Space Agency Race

2–4 Players · Ages 12+ · 30–45 Minutes